



Taunting the enemy

Winslow Homer's *Defiance: Inviting a Shot Before Petersburg* (1864) shows a Confederate soldier standing on the earthworks taunting Union sharpshooters. On one such occasion the man was instantly shot.

Mining the line

As the standoff settled into a lethal stalemate, members of the 48th Pennsylvania Volunteers, who had been coal miners in civilian life, persuaded their commander, Lieutenant Colonel Henry Pleasants, a mining engineer, that it was possible to dig a mine beneath a Confederate redoubt called Elliott's Salient, pack it with explosives, and blow a hole in the enemy lines. Though doubting its usefulness, Grant eventually approved the scheme.

Digging began on June 25 and by July 17 the miners had excavated a 510-ft (155-m) shaft, ending directly beneath Elliott's Salient, only 20ft (6m) above them. They had cleverly concealed their work, devising ingenious ways to provide ventilation. But the inevitable noise had alerted the Confederates who sank countermines in response. Those went wide of the mark, so the Pennsylvanians dug lateral tunnels—like the crossbar on a “T”—